



Solaris

for your Desktop

OpenSolaris 2008.11 is the latest release of the OpenSolaris operating system. In this article we take a look at what it has to offer, besides all that's new.

The OpenSolaris 2008.11 live CD boots to a minimal OS. You can explore the OpenSolaris OS on the CD without affecting the existing operating system on your laptop.



Note: If you already have OpenSolaris 2008.05 installed on your system, you can upgrade to 2008.11 without using the DVD by following the instructions here: tinyurl.com/opensolaris-upgrade-200811

Get it installed

OpenSolaris 2008.11 requires a minimum of 512 MB of RAM and a primary partition with a minimum of 3.1 GB of disk space (though at least 9 GB is recommended). If you do not already have an unused primary partition, use a tool like GParted to create one for OpenSolaris. You can set the partition type to 'Linux SWAP' for the time being. Make sure you back up any important data on the machine before resizing/creating partitions.

IMPORTANT: If you are installing OpenSolaris on a system that already has Linux installed, remember to boot into Linux and back up the `/boot/grub/menu.lst` file—copy it to a thumb drive, mail it to your GMail account

or even just write it down on a piece of paper. OpenSolaris overwrites the installed GRUB with its own version during the installation. You will need to add the entries you had in your Linux `menu.lst` file after installation.

Insert the OpenSolaris live CD into the computer and set up the BIOS to boot from the CD drive, then boot into the live CD. Choose the first boot entry in the boot menu. After a while, it will go to the console mode and ask you to choose your keyboard layout. Defaults will suffice in most cases. In a few minutes, you should be looking at the blue GNOME desktop (Figure 1).

This release includes much better hardware support compared to previous releases. You can use the Device Driver Utility (DDU) on the live CD to check if any of the hardware on your system is not supported (Figure 2). [After installation, you can find the DDU under *Applications*→*System Tools*→*Device Driver Utility*.] If everything is fine, you're ready to take it for a ride... err, I mean, install it on your hard disk.

Double click the 'Install OpenSolaris' icon from the live desktop. (If you are prompted at any point to log into the live CD, both the user name and password are 'jack'. The root